

Online Safety, Mobile Phone and Internet Use Policy

SECTIONS 1-4: PURPOSE, SCOPE, RESPONSIBILITIES & DEVICE MANAGEMENT

1 PURPOSE

To protect children and young people from online risks including grooming, exploitation, cyberbullying and harmful content while promoting safe and responsible use of technology and the internet in accordance with Children First 2017, Tusla guidance, HIQA National Standards and GDPR.

2 SCOPE

- ✓ All children and young people, staff and visitors using digital devices
- ✓ Mobile phones, tablets, computers, gaming and social media
- ✓ Prevention, education, monitoring and response across all settings
- ✓ Balancing rights to communication with safety needs

3 RESPONSIBILITIES

- ✓ **Provider & PIC:** Ensure filtering, monitoring tools and resources
- ✓ **Care Staff & Key Workers:** Supervise use, deliver education and report concerns
- ✓ **Management:** Review incidents and update risk assessments
- ✓ **IT/Safeguarding Leads:** Maintain technical safeguards
- ✓ **All Staff:** Model safe behaviour and complete training

4 DEVICE MANAGEMENT

- ✓ Individual risk-assessed agreements for device use developed on placement
- ✓ Age-appropriate rules, time limits and app approvals in place
- ✓ Filtering and monitoring software regularly reviewed
- ✓ Devices checked or restricted at agreed times with explanation
- ✓ Clear consequences for misuse applied consistently

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SECTIONS 5-7: EDUCATION & AWARENESS, REPORTING & RISK RESPONSE

5 EDUCATION & AWARENESS

- ✓ Regular engaging online safety sessions delivered using approved resources
- ✓ Young people involved in co-creating rules and campaigns
- ✓ Topics include grooming, sexting, privacy and cyberbullying
- ✓ Family guidance provided on supporting safe use
- ✓ Integrated into care plans and key worker sessions

6 REPORTING & RISK RESPONSE

- ✓ Any online concern reported immediately to the DLP
- ✓ Evidence preserved and young person supported without delay
- ✓ Escalation to Tusla, Gardaí or specialist services where required
- ✓ Restorative and educational responses alongside sanctions
- ✓ Impact on wellbeing addressed in care plans

7 SPECIFIC RISKS

- ✓ Procedures for child sexual and criminal exploitation online included
- ✓ Response to sexting, image sharing and cyberbullying
- ✓ Risk assessments updated for vulnerable young people
- ✓ Links to self-harm and safeguarding policies maintained
- ✓ Secure handling of digital records

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SECTIONS 8-10: COMPLIANCE, MONITORING & POLICY REVIEW

8 COMPLIANCE & TRAINING

- ✓ All staff complete online safety and digital safeguarding training
- ✓ Technical safeguards audited regularly
- ✓ Policy communicated in accessible formats to young people
- ✓ GDPR compliance in digital records
- ✓ Immediate action on breaches

9 MONITORING & REVIEW

- ✓ Audits of incident logs, risk assessments and training
- ✓ Feedback from young people, families and staff
- ✓ Analysis of trends and emerging risks
- ✓ Compliance with individual plans monitored
- ✓ Staff competency assessed in supervision

10 POLICY REVIEW

- ✓ Reviewed annually or sooner if required
- ✓ Incorporates audits, feedback and regulatory updates
- ✓ Considers new platforms and threats
- ✓ Reviewed policy approved by Registered Provider and communicated to all staff
- ✓ Superseded versions archived per record management procedures